Ten AI prompts that pay for themselves at work

Paste into Microsoft 365 Copilot, Claude or ChatGPT. Replace the [brackets]. Always read the answer before you send it anywhere.

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01 Meeting notes into minutes

> Here are my raw notes from a meeting: [paste]. Turn them into minutes with three sections: Decisions, Actions (owner, due date, one line each), Open questions. Keep every name. If something is unclear, list it under Open questions instead of guessing.

Why it works: it names the structure and bans guessing, which is where meeting summaries usually go wrong.

02 The five-line status

> Turn these updates into a status note for an executive who has 30 seconds: [paste]. Five lines max: what changed this week, what is at risk, what I need from them, next milestone and date, one-word RAG rating with a reason.

Why it works: executives read for risk and asks. This puts both above the fold.

03 Inbox triage and reply

> Summarize this email thread in three bullets, tell me exactly what is being asked of me and by when, then draft a reply in my voice: short, direct, friendly, no corporate filler. Thread: [paste].

Why it works: separating "what is being asked" from the draft stops you answering the wrong question well.

04 Deck outline for a decision

> I need a six-slide deck to get approval for [decision] from [audience]. Give me a slide title that states the point for each slide, one supporting message per slide, and two lines of speaker notes. Slide 6 is the ask with options.

Why it works: titles that state the point force the story before you touch PowerPoint.

05 Explain it back, then question it

> Explain this document to me as if I just joined the team: [paste]. Then list the five questions I should ask before agreeing to it, and the one assumption it relies on most.

Why it works: you get the summary and the skepticism in one pass, before the meeting rather than after.

06 The pre-mortem

> Pretend it is six months from now and [project] has failed. Write the three most likely post-mortems in two paragraphs each, then for each one, the single action we would wish we had taken this month.

Why it works: imagining failure as already happened produces far more honest risks than "what could go wrong?"

07 Spreadsheet formula, explained

> In Excel I have columns [A: ..., B: ..., C: ...]. I want [the result in plain words]. Write the formula, explain each part in one line, and tell me the two ways it could silently give a wrong answer.

Why it works: the "silently wrong" line catches blanks, text-as-numbers and off-by-one ranges.

08 Customer reply that keeps the customer

> Draft a reply to this customer message: [paste]. Acknowledge the specific problem in the first sentence, explain what happened without excuses, offer a concrete next step with a date, under 120 words, warm and plain, no "we apologize for any inconvenience".

Why it works: structure plus a word budget removes the padding customers hate.

09 Learn it in ten minutes

> Teach me [topic] in ten minutes for a [my role]. The five ideas that matter most, one worked example, the mistake beginners make, and three questions I can ask an expert to sound like I did my homework.

Why it works: it asks for the shape of the subject, not a textbook, and ends with questions you can actually use.

10 The Friday review

> Here is my calendar and task list for the week: [paste]. Tell me what moved the needle toward [my top goal], what consumed time without moving it, and the three things to drop, delegate or shorten next week. Be blunt.

Why it works: an outside view of your own week is the cheapest productivity gain there is.

Want these set up in your tools, on your real work? Book an AI Power Hour: https://www.yoergoodsdigital.com/ai/

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